around it for a few minutes and came back to the starting point. "Such a big banyan tree?" exclaimed Ponni and Velan.

"This is a very big banyan tree and is the oldest in this forest. It is the habitat of thousands of birds. It is as famous as the banyan tree in the Indian Botanical Garden in Howrah (Calcutta)," said Manimaran.

"There is another big banyan in Adyar (Chennai). It is as big as that. I saw that when I visited the Theosophical Society and wondered at it." said Ponni.

"Let us now go slowly because there is a herd of elephants climbing the mountains right behind the banyan tree" said Manimaran.

Velan replied at once, "Oh! Aren't the wild elephants ferocious? Are we in danger?".

Manimaran said "First and foremost we are not supposed to trouble the wild animals because the forest is their home. We can admire them without disturbing them."

Manimaran continued "We should know how to safeguard ourselves from the encounters of the wild animals. That is the reason why we try to explore the forests with the guides who belong to the forest tribal community".

"Even though the animals are quite huge, they will not harm you unless you hurt them".

"Let us also climb the hills along with the elephants. There is another surprise waiting for you on the top of the hills" said Manimaran.

After climbing the hill they came across a plain. He parked the vehicle and asked the team to see something using their binoculars. "Look there,"

There was a cone-shaped nest built with dried leaves. Manimaran asked, "Can you guess which animal's nest is that?

I know that birds build nests on the ground, but this seems a bit strange," said Veena.

It is a snake's nest, the nest of king cobra".

"What? Snakes build nests?" said Velan.

"This is the only reptile that builds a nest of its own and reproduces. Thus snake's average length is 18 feet and is the longest of the poisonous snakes" said Manimaran.

"We have explored the forest and climbed the hills but we have not seen a tiger till now" said Ponni.

"Don't worry Ponni. We have come across many wonders. The Tiger is a very shy animal. While descending down the hills we may see one on the rocky area on the slope" said Manimaran.

They had seen many unusual things that day. But they were very disappointed because they had not seen ever a tiger."

"I have visited several forests but they are not identical. I got some new information from Mr.Manimaran and the tribals. I have visited forestes many times regarding my research. But I was not able to see the tiger. Don't worry, we will see a tiger some time later comforted Veena.

6th_CIVICS_IInd Term_UNIT 1.indd 162 09-07-2019 11.58.53 AM